

Serveo, without the mystery

A plain-English guide to the temporary public tunnel used to open the Snake dashboard from your phone.

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3-page cheatsheet

THE 20-SECOND ANSWER

Serveo is a relay. It gives a local web app a temporary public address, then forwards visits through an outbound Secure Shell (SSH) connection.

The VM initiates the connection. Serveo does not need a new inbound firewall port, a VPN membership, or general shell access to the VM.

WHAT APPROVAL MEANS

Allow one temporary tunnel from the VM to `serveo.net`, forwarding only the dashboard's chosen local port.

It does not authorize exposing other ports, files, terminals, or services.

Traffic follows one narrow path

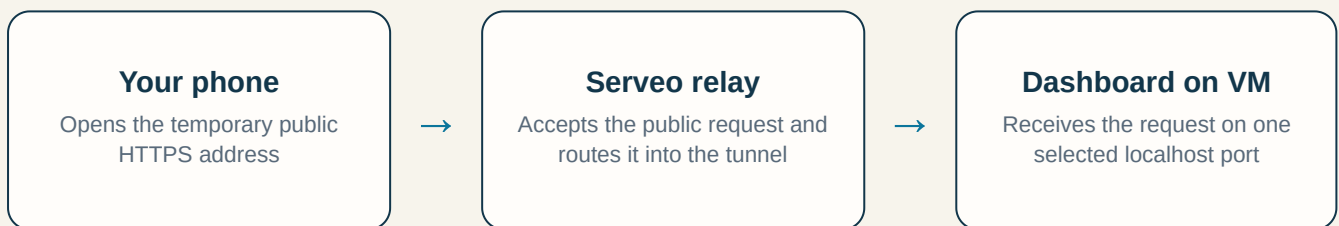


Figure 1. HTTPS protects the public leg; SSH protects the reverse-tunnel leg.

SERVEO CARRIES

- Dashboard page requests and responses.
- Button clicks and values submitted through the dashboard.
- WebSocket traffic if the dashboard uses it.

SERVEO DOES NOT AUTOMATICALLY GET

- A shell on the VM or broad filesystem access.
- Access to ports that were not forwarded.
- Model traffic that the dashboard server sends directly to a configured model endpoint.

IMPORTANT DISTINCTION

Encrypted is not the same as private

The route is encrypted in transit, but the generated address is publicly reachable. If the dashboard has no sign-in, possession of the URL is effectively the access control. Treat Serveo as part of the request path: do not type long-lived API keys, passwords, private files, or other secrets into an unauthenticated tunneled dashboard.

Use it like a temporary guest door

Open only what you need, share the address narrowly, and close it when the demo is over.

Quick reference
Snake dashboard

Approval checklist

- ☐ **Scope:** one local dashboard port only.
- ☐ **Duration:** temporary; the tunnel ends with the SSH process.
- ☐ **Audience:** only people who receive the generated address.
- ☐ **Data:** no passwords, API keys, tokens, private files, or sensitive records entered through the dashboard.
- ☐ **Control:** keep the local app bound to localhost and forward no unrelated service.
- ☐ **Closeout:** stop the SSH process when testing is complete.

NARROW APPROVAL STATEMENT

I approve a temporary outbound SSH connection to Serveo for the Snake dashboard, limited to its selected localhost port and active only for this testing session.

This wording does not approve persistent startup, additional ports, credentials in the dashboard, or unrelated services.

Know the controls

Start

```
ssh -R 80:localhost:<LOCAL_PORT>  
serveo.net
```

Serveo prints the assigned public address after the connection starts. Substitute the dashboard's actual port.

Stop immediately

```
Ctrl+C
```

If the tunnel runs as a background process, terminate that SSH process. The public route should stop when the SSH session ends.

Check the local app first

```
curl http://localhost:<LOCAL_PORT>
```

A local response proves the app is listening. It does not prove the public tunnel is active.

Expect a warning page

Serveo says anonymous and free-account HTTP tunnels show an interstitial browser warning. Continue only when the hostname ends in `.serveo.net` and matches the address printed by the tunnel session.

Command anatomy: `ssh` opens the encrypted client connection; `-R` requests reverse forwarding; `80:localhost:<LOCAL_PORT>` points Serveo's HTTP entry to one local port; `serveo.net` is the relay host.

Public for a moment still means public

The safest tunnel is narrow, short-lived, and carries no secret the dashboard does not need.

Security
reference
Snake dashboard

MAIN RISKS

- **Public reachability:** an unprotected dashboard can be opened by anyone who obtains the URL.
- **Third-party relay:** Serveo operates the internet-facing endpoint and sits in the traffic path. Do not assume the relay is a private vault.
- **Abuse and scanning:** public tunnel addresses can attract automated traffic.
- **Availability:** a free relay may disconnect or change the assigned address; it is for testing, not production.

Safer operating pattern

1. Run the dashboard on localhost, not every network interface.
2. Open the tunnel only when you are ready to test.
3. Share the exact generated link privately.
4. Keep secrets out of the dashboard; use server-side credential storage.
5. Stop the tunnel after the test and confirm the public link no longer responds.

CLOSEOUT TEST

After stopping SSH, reload the public link. A failed connection confirms the relay no longer reaches the dashboard. Also verify no replacement or auto-reconnect process is running.

PRIVATE ALTERNATIVE

Host the dashboard on a device already reachable through your private Tailscale network. That avoids a public relay entirely.

What the official documentation confirms

Documented behavior	Practical meaning
SSH reverse forwarding assigns a public subdomain.	The local app becomes reachable from the internet through a Serveo address.
Anonymous use is supported.	A basic tunnel may not require an account or registered key.
Free and anonymous HTTP tunnels display an interstitial warning.	Your browser may show Serveo's warning page before the dashboard.
Port 443 is available when outbound port 22 is blocked.	The SSH tunnel can use a network path that often works in restrictive environments.

Sources and limits

Serveo describes itself as a remote-port-forwarding service that provides a public URL through SSH and supports access from mobile devices. Features and limits may change, so recheck the official documentation before relying on it for persistent or production access.

Official references: serveo.net | serveo.net/docs | accessed 24 September 2026.